Checklist: Usability Testing

Introduction

Use this checklist to plan and facilitate a short, moderated usability test. The goal is to observe representative users attempting realistic tasks—not to teach, persuade, or test the participant.

- ☐ Define what you need to learn and which product, page, feature, or flow you will test.
- ☐ Identify the target audience and recruit representative participants. For a small qualitative study focused on one user group, five participants is a common starting point.
- ☐ Choose a realistic test environment, device, website, or prototype and verify that it works before the session.
- ☐ Prepare consent, privacy, recording, note-taking, and accessibility arrangements before participants arrive.
- ☐ Tell participants: ‘We are testing the design, not you. There are no wrong answers.’
- ☐ Ask participants to think aloud so you can hear their expectations, decisions, and confusion.
- ☐ Use the same core introduction and task order for each participant so sessions are comparable.
- ☐ Plan who will facilitate, take notes, manage recording, and observe without interrupting.

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Create Questions

Write task prompts that describe a believable situation and a goal. Avoid telling participants which button, menu, label, or path to use. Follow each task with neutral, open-ended probes.

- ☐ Write tasks that are realistic for the intended audience and meaningful for the research goal.
- ☐ Describe the desired outcome—not the interface steps. Let participants choose their own path.
- ☐ Avoid words that appear in the interface when those words would give away the answer.
- ☐ Give one task at a time and ask the participant to read it aloud before beginning.
- ☐ Keep task wording short, specific, neutral, and free of praise, criticism, or assumptions.
- ☐ Include both observable task prompts and open-ended opinion or emotion questions when useful.
- ☐ Use neutral probes instead of leading questions: echo the participant's words, ask 'What would you normally do?', or pause after an incomplete prompt such as 'You seem to be looking for…'
- ☐ Do not rescue participants too quickly. If they ask what to do, first ask what they would expect or try next.
- ☐ Pilot the questions with one person and revise any prompt that causes confusion unrelated to the design.

EXAMPLE QUESTIONS

- Your printer is showing "Error 5200." How can you get rid of the error message?
- You're considering opening a new credit card with Wells Fargo. Please visit wellsfargo.com and decide which credit card you might want to open, if any.
- Say you wanted to find the results of our team's latest game. Walk me through how you would find this on the site.
- Step through the process of adding a sopapilla to your cart.
- What's your opinion on how the information is laid out?
- How does this page or feature make you feel?

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Follow-Up Questions

Ask brief follow-up questions immediately after each task, then end with an open debrief. Listen without defending the design or explaining what participants were supposed to do.

- ☐ Ask how easy or difficult the task felt and what influenced that rating.
- ☐ Ask what the participant expected to happen before a confusing or surprising moment.
- ☐ Ask for the participant's own words instead of suggesting an answer or emotion.
- ☐ When a participant gives a short answer, use a neutral follow-up such as 'Tell me more about that.'
- ☐ Separate what you observed from your interpretation in the notes.
- ☐ Record task completion, errors, hesitation, workarounds, quotes, and requests for help.
- ☐ After all sessions, group repeated observations and prioritize issues by impact, frequency, and severity.
- ☐ Translate findings into specific design recommendations and identify what should be tested next.

EXAMPLE POST-TEST QUESTIONS

- Overall, how easy or difficult was it to complete that task?
- What did you find most frustrating or confusing about the experience?
- What surprised you the most while navigating through this?
- If you could change one thing about this design or flow, what would it be?

Facilitator Reminders

- ☐ Talk less than the participant. Observe and listen.
- ☐ Do not lead, praise, correct, teach, or react visibly to success or failure.
- ☐ Do not turn the session into a casual conversation; keep the participant focused on the experience.
- ☐ Thank the participant and explain what will happen with the feedback.

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Sources

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